Establishment (AFCME) in Delhi for an appeal to the medical board, where my weight would be rechecked, as per the commandant's directions. But this wasn't the worst part. The minimum required height for a female officer for flying was 162.5 cm. When they told me that I was only 161.5 cm and therefore eligible only for ground duty and not flying, I almost cried in disappointment. But then, the commandant told me that I still had a chance, for an appeal medical board would hear this rejection as well. It didn't help to lift my spirits but I listened to him carefully. Everything had been going so well, and then suddenly I was being told that I wasn't eligible to fly! All my dreams came crashing down. The only reason I had chosen to become an officer in the Indian Air Force was because I wanted to fly. And knowing that I would never fly, just because of a mere centimetre, was very upsetting. The moment the board handed over my documents and dismissed me, I ran straight to the PCO and dialled home.

'Don't fret, Gunju, just come back home,' he said after I told him about the board's decision. 'We will figure this out. You still have an appeal medical board.'

'But Papa, I can't increase my height,' I said, upset.

'You just come home, beta. We'll figure everything out,' he said. 'You came all this way and got recommended on your very first attempt. You passed all your tests. You were excellent at the PABT. You cannot let one centimetre decide your fate. You're meant to fly, I just know you are. For now, just come home. We miss you.' Still wondering what would happen and how, I hung up and started for Hema's house.

Hema left no stone unturned to cheer me up when I told her everything. 'Amma told me that there have been cases where up to two centimetres of difference have been waived off for male candidates. I'm sure the appeal medical board will yield positive results,' she said.

'Losing weight is possible. But there's no way I can increase my height,' I said.

'You might never have to,' Hema said. 'Cheer up now! At least you're still getting a chance to wear the uniform. Rejoice in this fact. Let's go for dinner.'